Sherif Abaza

Director of Events | Flagship Conferences, Summits and Large-Scale Event Production

Valkenswaard, Netherlands (open to relocation to Santa Clara, CA; available for 60% domestic and international travel) | +31 6 2306 3073 | sabaza@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/sabaza

SUMMARY

Events director with 20+ years of event management experience and 15+ years leading teams and businesses. I founded and led **Sphere Events** to a **140-person, USD 8M+ business** delivering **150+ events a year**: multi-day conferences, innovation fairs, executive forums and festival franchises for clients including **Siemens, Ericsson, Porsche, Cartier and Emaar**. I have led delivery of client programmes at **three consecutive UN climate summits (COP27, COP28, COP29)**, multi-day events of 40,000+ delegates combining plenaries, side events, exhibition pavilions, networking and heads-of-state programmes.

I own flagship events end to end, as the single point of strategic and operational accountability: event strategy and structure with senior leadership, master timelines, venue and agency selection, staging, A/V, broadcast and on-site logistics, and budget ownership through to post-event measurement. Eight years on the executive team at Withlocals added the cross-functional side: aligning product, engineering, operations and commercial teams behind company priorities.

CORE SKILLS

- Strategic event management and flagship event strategy
- Large-scale, multi-day conferences and summits
- Plenaries, keynotes, exhibitions and networking
- Budget management and P&L ownership
- Stage production, A/V, live streaming and broadcast
- Venue management and venue selection
- Agency, vendor and supplier management
- Master event timelines and on-site operations
- Executive communications and stakeholder management
- Cross-functional leadership
- Creative and experiential direction
- Post-event measurement and reporting
- Heads-of-state, executive and VVIP programmes
- AI tools across event planning and delivery

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Abaza Business Services · Valkenswaard, Netherlands / Global

Founder & Managing Director | Jan 2019 – Present

- Strategic and operational events partner to **Barry Callebaut** across its global event portfolio, including the **World Chocolate Masters 2026**, the first **Callebaut Innovation Summit** and its global leadership conferences: event strategy and structure, budget ownership and financial oversight, executive stakeholder alignment, venue and agency selection, master timelines and on-site production.
- Led end-to-end delivery of client programmes at **COP27 (Egypt), COP28 (UAE) and COP29 (Azerbaijan)**, multi-day summits combining plenaries, side events, exhibition pavilions and networking: programme planning, master timelines, multinational teams and on-site logistics, working directly with heads-of-state, ministerial and senior stakeholder groups and global media.
- Events Director and Technical Director for global experiential agencies **Jack Morton, Shelton Fleming and Impact XM**, leading staging, A/V, venue and vendor teams for their clients' programmes in-market.
- Event programme strategy for **NBA** market-entry initiatives in Europe and Africa, working with senior league stakeholders.
- Designed and shipped two software products through AI coding agents, and use AI daily across RFP and budget analysis, supplier comparisons and run-of-show drafting.

Sphere Events and Communication · Dubai, UAE

Founder & Managing Director | Aug 2008 – Oct 2018

- Founded and led the company for ten years, growing it from a sole operator to **140 people and USD 8M+** in annual revenue, with full P&L accountability for a portfolio of **150+ events a year and 800+ in total**.
- Strategic events partner to **Siemens, Ericsson, Porsche, Cartier and Emaar**, owning multi-day conferences, innovation fairs and executive forums across the full lifecycle: event strategy and creative direction, budgets, venue and vendor management, production, on-site delivery and post-event measurement.
- Ran production end to end: staging and rigging, sound and lighting, LED and screens, power, broadcast and live streaming, and technical rehearsals, with crews working to a single run-of-show.
- Built original event properties **Street Nights, Marina Music Festival and Dubai Chocolate Festival** into recurring franchises with their own sponsors and public-sector partners, for audiences of tens of thousands.

- Expanded into sport and gaming, including the **KitKat 3x3 basketball tournament** and **esports tournaments** with broadcast production.
- Built the operational playbooks, supplier frameworks and QA processes that kept quality consistent across formats and markets.

Withlocals B.V. · Eindhoven, Netherlands
Chief Community Officer | Jul 2022 – Jul 2026

- Built and scaled the global supply and community organisation for a technology-driven travel and experiences marketplace.
- Managed relationships with **2,000+ experience hosts across 80+ countries**, keeping quality consistent across markets, much like running a large supplier and vendor network.

Chief Growth Officer | Nov 2018 – Jul 2022

- Scaled the marketplace from 50 to **300+ cities**, building data-driven frameworks for market prioritisation and operational efficiency.
- Led the pivot to virtual and hybrid experiences during the pandemic, launching a proprietary platform that served **70+ global corporate clients**. That was in effect a B2B events business inside the marketplace.
- Partnered with Product and Engineering on the internal tools and dashboards behind host performance, retention and operational clarity.

FrontFlip (me360) · Kansas City, USA / MENA
CEO, Middle East & North Africa | Mar 2010 – May 2015

- Co-founded and led the regional business of a mobile loyalty and engagement startup, raising **USD 1.8M** in early-stage funding and building a 35-person cross-functional team.
- Led market localisation, UX design and rollout of one of the region's earliest app-based customer engagement platforms.

Sundance Events · Dubai, UAE
Business Development & Operations Manager | Jan 2006 – Aug 2008

- Events business development and operational delivery for corporate and government clients across the UAE.
- Built the client relationships and supplier network that laid the foundation for founding Sphere Events.

ASDAA Burson-Marsteller · Dubai, UAE
Senior Account Manager | Sep 2004 – Dec 2005

- Communications strategy for Siemens, Adidas and Hilton across the Middle East.
- Key role producing the inaugural **Dubai International Film Festival**.

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Computer Engineering
Arab Academy for Science, Technology and Maritime Transport, Alexandria, Egypt

LEADERSHIP

AIESEC International
Local Committee President; National Support Team | 1999 – 2004

LANGUAGES

Arabic (native), English (native), French (excellent), Spanish (excellent), Dutch (working), Polish (working), Portuguese, Italian and Romanian (basic)

WORK AUTHORISATION

Dutch (EU) citizen